

Pigeons, known scientifically as *Columba livia*, are one of the most familiar and widespread bird species in the world. These birds have been companions to humans for thousands of years, adapting remarkably well to urban environments. Often referred to as rock doves, pigeons have a natural habitat that includes cliffs and rocky outcrops, which explains their affinity for the ledges and high-rise buildings in cities. The pigeon's history with humans dates back to ancient civilizations. They were domesticated over 5,000 years ago, initially for their meat and later for their remarkable homing ability. Pigeons have an extraordinary sense of direction and can find their way home over hundreds of miles. This homing instinct has made them invaluable as messengers throughout history.

During both World Wars, pigeons were used to carry critical messages across enemy lines, and many were decorated for their service. In terms of physical characteristics, pigeons are medium-sized birds with a robust body, short neck, and a slender bill. They typically have a greyish body with two black bars on their wings, though they can exhibit a wide range of colors and patterns due to selective breeding. Pigeons are known for their cooing calls and unique head-bobbing walk. Pigeons are also fascinating in their behavior and intelligence. They mate for life, and both parents share the responsibility of caring for their young. They build simple nests, often in protected, elevated spots, and lay one or two eggs per clutch. Pigeon chicks, known as squabs, are fed with a special substance called "pigeon milk," which is regurgitated by both parents. One of the most intriguing aspects of pigeons is their cognitive abilities. Studies have shown that pigeons can recognize themselves in a mirror, a trait rare in the animal kingdom and often associated with higher intelligence. They can also be trained to perform complex tasks and have excellent memory, capable of remembering human faces.